

AS GOOD AS HIS PROMISE

Politicians and their promises, seldom the twain meet. So, in the event of that rare occurrence, due note must surely be taken. As it was in the case of Gujarat chief minister Bhupendra Patel. The story dates back to last year, when, during a video interaction, Shamya Prajapati, a Class 1 student from a primary school in Banaskantha, asked him: "Dada, when will you come here?" Patel promised he would visit and, months later, lo and behold, he actually did. The CM met the young students, and sources tell us he was quite impressed by Shamya's shloka recital. He apparently encouraged her to "study hard, become a collector, and bring glory to the village". All's well that ends well, but then this was one of the easier promises to keep. The CM's critics say the harder part will be making good on those he made to the state.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ BREAKING THE NOIDA JINX

BACK IN FAVOUR

The 'Noida jinx'—that visiting Uttar Pradesh's flagship industrial hub would sound an electoral death knell for sitting CMs—was a thing for over three decades till Yogi Adityanath put an end to it by storming back to power in 2022 (he made over a dozen visits there in his first term). Now Samajwadi Party (SP) chief **Akhilesh Yadav**, who went nowhere near Noida during his time in the top post (2012-17), is revisiting his aversion to Noida.



From staying away even during the 2017 and 2022 poll campaigns, Akhilesh will now begin the party's 'Mission 2027' from here. The SP campaign will begin with a PDA or Pichhda (Backward Classes), Dalit and Alpsankhyak (Minorities) conference in Noida on March 28. So great had been his fear of the place that the SP chief had stayed away even during the last two poll campaigns. So, what changed? Party workers believe Yadav now thinks Noida may be unlucky for those in power but is auspicious for those in the opposition. Guess we'll know for sure in 2027.